

KASHMIR CONNECTION

The Jammu–Srinagar link has been in the works for decades, battling non-stop challenges, from unforgiving terrain and construction issues, to political troubles. Yet, the completion of each phase has improved connectivity and furthered the attempt to integrate a region that has for long been crucial to India's strategic interests.

Sir Pratap Singh, the Maharaja of Jammu and Kashmir (1848–1925), ordered the first surveys to explore a railway link to the Kashmir Valley in 1902. There were two possibilities: Abbottabad (in present-day Pakistan)–Srinagar and Jammu–Srinagar through Banihal. Both proved to be expensive endeavours and were abandoned.

Therefore, until 1947 and Independence, visitors to Kashmir followed a circuitous route that involved train travel until Rawalpindi (in present-day Pakistan) or Jammu and then a road journey into the Valley. Partition made matters even more complicated. Sialkot, the city that once provided the sole railway link to Jammu via a 43-km broad-gauge line operated by the North Western State Railway, became a part of Pakistan. By September 1947, train services were suspended and it fell upon the Indian Government to re-establish links with Jammu and Kashmir (J&K).



▲ **In this spectacular view**, a train can be seen passing through snowy Banihal in the Ramban district of J&K.